

I think that Descartes' first meditation is quite interesting and perhaps one of the most important meditation as it ironically lays the foundation for his subsequent meditations. The first meditation is called "Concerning Those Things That Can Be Called into Doubt"¹ which is centered around the idea that many things Descartes once thought was true he now knows is false. Descartes starts off by talking about how many things he thought true in his youth are certainly false and now he comes to question anything he subsequently built off of those false opinions and thoughts. Descartes points out it would be almost meaningless to attempt to look at each and every belief by itself and determine its truthfulness, rather he wishes to doubt the very foundation for which these beliefs arise. Descartes believes in this attack on the foundation "because undermining the foundations will cause whatever has been built upon them to crumble of its own accord, I will attack straightaway those principles which supported everything I once believed"². Thus, the first thing that Descartes attempts to doubt are his 5 senses, which I fear may end up a useless endeavor as if we establish the senses as trustworthy then it does not necessarily hold true that beliefs derived from the senses are true, as we can come to the wrong conclusions and proofs from correct concepts and vice versa. On the other hand, if we assert that the senses are to be doubted one can only end up in a state of endless doubt in which case I may argue ignorance would truly be bliss. There is the subtle third option of the senses being sometimes right and wrong but this if anything would simply fall into the second category of doubt. It is this third case in which I believe Descartes fell into noting that the senses can "deceive us when it is a question of very small and distant things"³ but also that it is hard to doubt certain parts of the senses such as simply "holding this sheet of paper"⁴. I also find it ironic that Descartes doubts what is perceived through the sense but not that the senses are his own. Additionally, I find it amusing that it seems that the senses which Descartes would doubt are those which are the sole contributor to the conclusion. For example, he doubts what he sees when far away is because his other senses cannot contribute to what it is that he is seeing. He doesn't appear to question things which he can see, feel and hear simultaneously but only those which he can perceive through only a single sense. However, he begins to doubt everything perceived by his senses because they can plausibly relate to that of a dream (perhaps he was quite the vivid lucid dreamer). Thus he comes to the conclusion that he could doubt anything in the material world such as "physics, astronomy, medicine"⁵ as they are all disciplines based in the material world. Descartes then argues that this is insufficient to doubt the mathematics since "whether I am awake or asleep, two plus three make five, and a square does not have more than four sides"⁶. To introduce doubt to these principles, Descartes proposes the existence of a God that is an evil genius of sorts, capable of doing "anything"⁷ and simply formulating the world Descartes perceives

¹René Descartes, MEDITATIONS ON FIRST PHILOSOPHY IN WHICH THE EXISTENCE OF GOD AND THE DISTINCTION BETWEEN THE SOUL AND THE BODY ARE DEMONSTRATED: 59.

²Descartes, Meditations: 60

³Descartes, Meditations: 60

⁴Descartes, Meditations: 60

⁵Descartes, Meditations: 61

⁶Descartes, Meditations: 61

⁷Descartes, Meditations: 61

now in such a sound way that it could not be doubted from the senses. Descartes supposes that this God is “not a supremely good God, the source of truth, but rather an evil genius, supremely powerful and clever, who has directed his entire effort at deceiving me”⁸. As such, Descartes concludes this meditation by asserting that “even if it is not within my power to know anything true, it certainly is within my power to take care resolutely to withhold my assent to what is false”⁹, which perhaps might be the most noble way of percieving the world that he writes off as something that we cannot know for sure is true.

⁸Descartes, Meditations: 62

⁹Descartes, Meditations: 63